Gujarat ka sher aya' (See, see, the lion of Gujarat has come). Modi was now pitched as a Gir lion and a modern-day Sardar Patel rolled into one.

The Gaurav Yatra was launched from the Bhathiji Maharaj temple in the village of Fagvel in early September. I was seated in the front row in the press enclosure when Modi spotted me. Pointing to me in his speech, he said, 'Some journalists come from Delhi and target our Gujarat. They say we failed to control the riots and damage the image of peace-loving Gujaratis; but you tell me, will we allow this conspiracy against Gujarat to continue?'

The combative tone had been set. For the next four weeks, Modi used the Gaurav Yatra to portray himself as the 'saviour' of Gujarat. When the Akshardham temple was attacked on 24 September while the yatra was on, Modi turned adversity into opportunity. It gave him a chance to attack Pakistan, and in particular, its president Pervez Musharraf. In every speech, he would refer to 'Miyan' Musharraf and blame him for terrorism. The public target may have been Musharraf, but the message was really aimed at local Muslim groups—the Godhra train burning, after all, was still fresh in public memory.

The distinctly communal edge to the Gaurav Yatra surfaced in its most vitriolic form during a rally in Becharji on 9 September. This is where Modi referred to the riot relief camps as 'baby-producing centres' with his infamous one-liner, *'Hum paanch, hamare pachhees'* (We five, our twenty-five). In an interview to his admirer Madhu Kishwar, Modi later claimed that he was not referring to relief camps but to the country's population problem. He told her, 'This phrase was not uttered just to target relief camps. I say it even now that the population of our country is increasing rapidly. Today, if a farmer has five sons, they will soon, between them, produce twenty-five.'

Few will buy Modi's explanation. The entire Gaurav Yatra was taking place against the backdrop of the riots. The tone of Modi's speeches was set by the fragility of communal relations and the climate of fear and hate that had been sparked off by the violence. That he was allowed to get away with such blatant appeals to religion reflects the limitations of the law and the